

Seeking Safety Through Generative AI to Navigate Abusive Situation

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Abstract

Designing Generative AI (GenAI) around human-centric principles is imperative and is receiving growing attention. Yet there remain many emerging domains where these principles have been less actively applied and explored. Among these, the use of GenAI by individuals navigating abusive situations is a domain that is critical, yet under-examined. With the accelerating adoption of GenAI across nearly every aspect of life, this evolving area requires further exploration and research to keep pace with its growth, remain human-centric, and realize its full potential. This position paper outlines a research agenda for exploring human behavior patterns among those seeking safety through GenAI, and proposes design and framing strategies through which such systems can be shaped to produce a meaningfully positive impact on mental wellness.

Keywords

Generative AI, Human-AI Interaction, HCI, Help-Seeking Behavior, Abusive Situations, Online Support, Safety

1 Introduction

Generative artificial intelligence (GenAI), particularly conversational AI systems, is becoming increasingly integrated into everyday decision-making and information-seeking. People use these tools for a wide range of purposes, including travel planning [17], financial decisions [14], cooking ideas [19], education [21], personal advice [13]. Regardless of whether users ultimately agree with or follow AI-provided suggestions, GenAI has the potential to influence how individuals interpret situations, consider alternatives, and make decisions in their everyday lives. This growing role of conversational AI also raises important questions about its use in sensitive and emotionally vulnerable circumstances.

One such context is abusive situations or relationships[cite]. Individuals involved in these situations may turn to GenAI to describe their experiences, interpret another person's behavior, seek advice, explore possible courses of action, or obtain emotional reassurance. Different individuals may interpret the same situation into different perspectives, making the interaction between users and GenAI complex. For individuals experiencing abuse, conversational AI may also offer certain perceived advantages over traditional sources of support, such as immediate availability, accessibility, and the ability to discuss sensitive experiences without directly disclosing them to another person. Barriers such as privacy concerns, fear of judgment, limited access to professional services, and the financial cost of professional support may further encourage some individuals to seek

assistance from easily accessible GenAI tools [1, 5, 15]. Gorissen [9] found that the disinhibition effect and perceived anonymity may lower the barriers to disclosing experiences of abuse on digital platforms. However, the growing use of GenAI in abusive situations highlights the need to understand how people seek and experience AI-mediated support, as well as how they evaluate their experience using it.

2 Research Background and Motivation

Seeking support in abusive situations is a domain that has multifaceted aspects. Research has been conducted from different perspectives. For instance, researchers explored the potential of GenAI, including its natural language processing capabilities, accessibility, availability, and others [10]. Shrivastava et al. (2024) examined the versatile applications of GenAI due to its strong natural language processing capabilities[18]. Their study demonstrates how GenAI can identify gender-based abuse, including verbal and psychological manipulation. Another study shows how GenAI techniques can be used to analyze diverse data formats, including text, images, videos, audio, and software files, to detect safety threats and attempts to manipulate security systems [6].

Other researchers studied people's preferences regarding what they want from GenAI. They found that preferences may differ based on age, sex, and other social demographics. Michal et al. observed that young adults prefer practical, action-oriented support from AI chatbots, rather than only emotional reassurance in sexual abuse and peer-pressure situations[12]. Another study on 622 young people shows that participants preferred AI responses for topics related to relationships, self-expression, and physical health. However, for highly sensitive issues like suicidal thoughts, they preferred responses written by humans [20]. The findings suggest that AI may not always be viewed as a replacement for human or professional support in abusive situations; rather, it can serve as a complementary resource, especially in high-risk situations.

Research also investigated how GenAI may also abuse and cause harm to its users. A study in 2025 explores how people may experience harmful behaviors from AI companions, such as relationship boundary violations, harassment, verbal abuse, self-harm-related content, misinformation, and privacy violations [22]. A study in 2023 explores how ChatGPT can be used to cause harm, like false authorship, plagiarism, hallucinations, misinformation and also the harmful design of ChatGPT, like algorithmic biasness, copyright, and others [7]. One study recommended stronger design standards, greater transparency, and appropriate regulatory safeguards to ensure that GenAI tools support survivors rather than put them at

further risk [16]. It evaluated 36 domestic violence support chatbots from 22 countries, including detailed testing of nine LLM-powered chatbots. It found major concerns related to privacy, transparency, usability, and safety. Many chatbots lacked appropriate privacy policies, failed to explain their limitations, and did not ask follow-up questions to understand survivors' needs. C Foriest et al. examined how survivors of intimate partner violence (IPV) use GenAI to disclose abuse and seek information or support [3]. They evaluated AI responses based on the usefulness of the information provided, readability, and potential risks. They also found that AI systems may sometimes create or reinforce unfairness by misunderstanding, dismissing, or inadequately responding to survivors' experiences.

Overall, previous research has examined GenAI from various perspectives, including its capabilities, users' expectations, comparisons among GenAI systems, and abuse from GenAIs. However, users' expectations of GenAI in abusive situations and the metrics for evaluating its support remain underexplored. Therefore, we propose the following research directions to conceptualize these underexplored areas and stimulate further discussion.

- How do people use GenAI to recognize or identify that they are experiencing an abusive situation?
- What types of support do people seek and receive from GenAI while navigating an abusive situation?
- How do people evaluate their experiences of receiving GenAI support in abusive situations?
- How can GenAI be shaped to provide better safety, security, and mental well-being for its users?

These research directions will not only explore users' experiences, expectations, and uses of GenAI but also identify potential ways to make GenAI more responsive to users' mental well-being.

3 Discussion

As the use of GenAI continues to increase, evaluation procedures, frameworks, policies, and guidelines must be regularly updated and adaptable to emerging risks. Recent research has recommended stronger evaluation frameworks, clearer policies, improved user-support systems, and strategies for creating safer GenAI environments [4, 8]. One potential safety feature can be to enable GenAI systems to **connect users with a trusted contact**, such as a friend, family member, or emergency helpline, when there are credible indications that the user may be at imminent risk of harming themselves or making a devastating decision. Such interventions, however, must be designed carefully to protect user privacy, consent, and others.

Another potential direction can be to position GenAI as a **bridge between a user experiencing abuse and professional counseling services** when clinical guidance or specialized support is needed. GenAI systems should respond compassionately and consider each user's circumstances. A recent study found that GenAI provided different responses to the same question depending on the user's role and situation [11]. However, compassion alone may not be sufficient in high-risk or complex situations where intervention from a qualified mental health professional is necessary. In such cases, GenAI could facilitate access to an appropriate registered counseling service while protecting their privacy and safety.

In a rapidly evolving world, GenAI may encounter complex or exceptional situations. Therefore, GenAI systems can be equipped with some features that allow users to request a review of potentially harmful, inaccurate, or inappropriate responses from GenAI. Such requests could be forwarded to a human-led evaluation team for further assessment, helping reduce the risk of harm caused by GenAI responses. This evaluation process should follow an adaptable framework that evolves with emerging risks and users' needs. Recent research has found that current evaluations of AI-based mental health tools often overlook clinical accuracy, user experience, safety, and fairness, and has proposed evaluating different types of AI mental health support according to their specific purposes and risks [2].

Overall, GenAI systems should be human-centered and responsive to improvements through evaluations. Continuous research, evaluation, and monitoring are essential to ensure that these systems remain focused on users' needs and contribute to broader social good. Future researchers can work on developing connection mechanisms with trusted contacts or professionals, empowering users with some GenAI features to review potentially harmful responses from GenAI, and lastly building a framework for evaluating abusive situations or relationships.

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